

A Guide to Consumer Remuneration

Paying people properly is the clearest signal that you value what they bring.

Whether and how you pay consumers tells them what you think their contribution is worth. This is a short, practical guide to getting it right. It is general guidance, not financial or legal advice; check your own policies and any tax or income-support implications with the right people.

Why it matters

Asking people to contribute expertise for free, while everyone else in the room is paid, sends a message no amount of thanks undoes. Remuneration is not a nicety. It is recognition that lived experience is expertise, and that giving it takes time, energy, and often a personal toll.

Start from a rate, not a gift

Decide a clear, defensible rate for consumer time and apply it consistently, the way you would for any other contributor. Vary it for the depth of the ask, not for who is asking. A one-off review and an ongoing advisory role are different commitments, and pay should reflect that.

Pay for the whole ask

Time in the room is rarely the whole job. Preparation, reading, travel, and the emotional labour of revisiting hard experience are all part of it. Budget for access and support costs separately, so the payment for time stays whole.

Make it easy to receive

A payment that takes months, demands complex paperwork, or risks someone's income support is not really payment. Offer options, be clear about timing, and warn people in advance about anything that could affect a benefit, so they can choose what suits them.

Be transparent

Share how you remunerate, so people know what to expect before they say yes. Transparency turns payment from a favour granted into a standard upheld.